

OIL ANALYST

Risks From Lower Gulf Flows and Higher China Imports

- **Physical market is tightening.** The recent Middle East escalation pushed Brent prices back into the mid-80s and reversed an initially sharp recovery in Persian Gulf flows. Meanwhile, price-sensitive Chinese crude imports – whose decline has cushioned the Hormuz disruption – may have bottomed after Middle Eastern producers cut official selling prices for July–August. We assess the durability of both the Persian Gulf flows recovery and of the decline in Chinese imports, and draw implications for crude prices.
- **Flows recovery lost its momentum.** We estimate that Gulf exports recovered to more than 80% of pre-war levels in the first two weeks after the MoU, but fell back to below 50% (11mb/d) after renewed attacks on tankers in the Strait ([Exhibit 1](#)). This setback leaves the oil market short 13.4mb/d of Persian Gulf flows and, absent near-term de-escalation, would likely require greater demand destruction and renewed inventory draws ([Exhibit 2](#)). That said, the latest estimates of observable Gulf flows may understate actual total Gulf flows as some tankers reportedly cross the Strait with transponders turned off. Most “dark-crossing” tankers eventually switch their signals back on outside the Strait, leading to meaningful upside revisions to flows: observable mid-June Gulf exports are now 1.1mb/d (10%) above the initial estimate from a month ago ([Exhibit 3](#)).
- **Further recovery in Gulf flows remains uncertain and likely uneven:**
 - Geopolitical escalation—particularly further potential attacks on oil tankers and energy infrastructure—remains the main downside risk to the recovery in Persian Gulf flows and production. Based on the April US blockade, we estimate that the newly reinstated blockade of Iranian ports and coastal areas could reduce Iranian exports by 1.5-2mb/d.
 - The next phase of Gulf flow recovery could be slower than the initial phase even after geopolitical de-escalation. First, Saudi Arabia and the UAE – producers with the largest tanker capacity and high-quality fields – drove most of the June rebound in the flows ([Exhibit 5](#)). UAE production likely already exceeded its pre-war level in June, while other crude production losses (vs. February levels) may still total around 9mb/d ([Exhibit 6](#)). Second, shippers using the non-Iranian Hormuz lane remain risk-averse, with flows through Omani and international routes declining sharply after the recent tanker attacks ([Exhibit 7](#)). Uncertainty and lingering regional risks had

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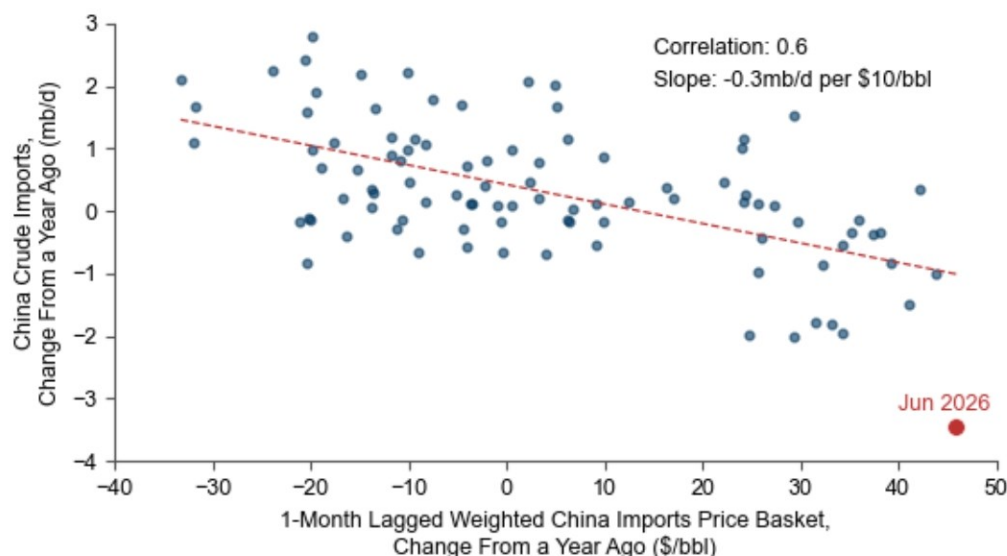
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already weighed on activity by non-Middle Eastern and private shippers even before the latest escalation ([Exhibit 8](#)).

- **China crude imports may have bottomed.** China crude net imports fell by 5mb/d year-over-year in June, even as imports by its Asian neighbors had recovered to seasonal norms ([Exhibit 9](#)). In our view, China crude imports need not rebound immediately, given still-elevated estimated total oil inventories of 1.9 billion barrels (117 days of demand) and its ability to substitute some oil demand by coal and power. Still, China crude imports are likely to rise for three reasons.
 - a. The imports' decline appears unusually large relative to the price increase ([Exhibit 10](#)).
 - b. Historical price sensitivity suggests an imports' rebound after Middle Eastern producers cut July–August selling prices below regional benchmarks.
 - c. Sustained crude destocking at an estimated 2mb/d pace would likely be inconsistent with Beijing's long-term goal of building inventory buffers.
- **Short-term upside risks to prices, medium-term downside.** We continue to see two-sided risks to our Brent crude price forecast of \$80 in 2026Q4 and \$75 in 2027, with risks skewed to the upside in the near term as the risk of further attacks on tankers and Middle East energy infrastructure has increased ([Exhibit 11](#)). Brent could overshoot \$110/bbl in 2026Q4 if the Gulf export recovery continues to stall, delaying the production rebound and requiring a larger demand response. Conversely, June's swift recovery in flows showed that Gulf exports can rebound quickly after de-escalation, with Brent potentially falling in the \$60s by year-end if production beats expectations and demand recovers more slowly amid high retail fuel prices.

Large Crude Stockpiles Allow China Imports to Be Price Sensitive and Postpone Imports When Crude Prices Are High



The sample is January 2017 to June 2026, excluding March–May 2020. The crude prices included are Arab Light (Saudi Arabia), Iran Heavy (Iran), Basrah Medium (Iraq), Murban (UAE), Oman Crude (Oman), ESPO Kozmino (Russia).

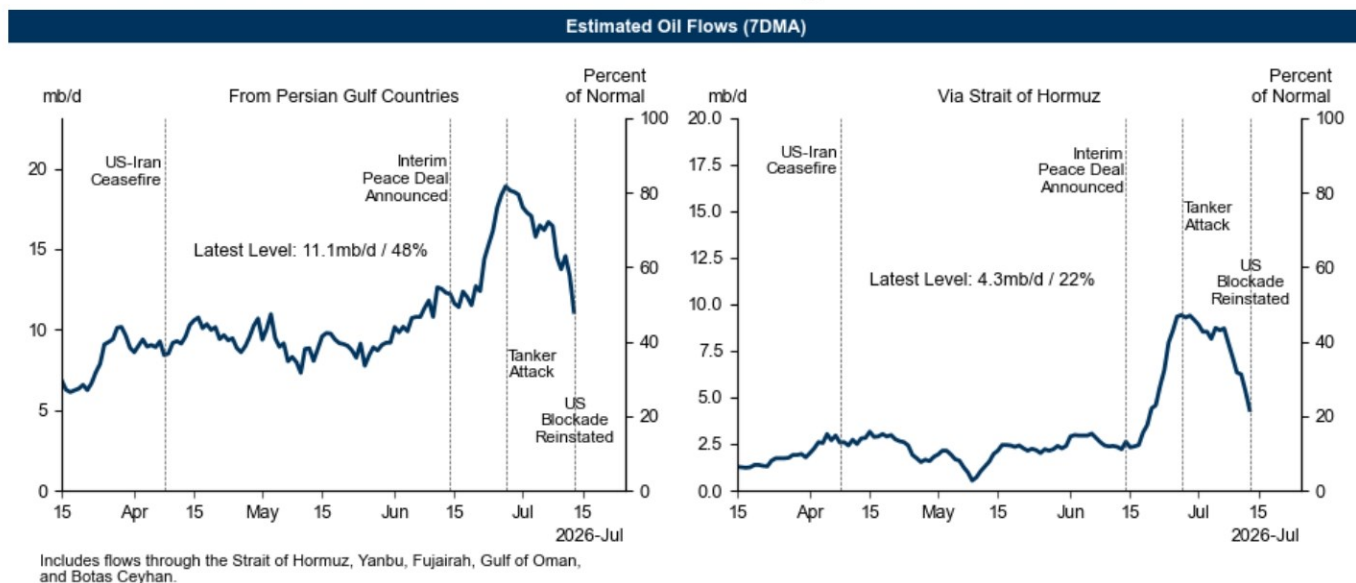
Source: Platts, OPEC, Kpler, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Risks From Lower Gulf Flows and Higher China Imports

Persian Gulf Flows Are Falling

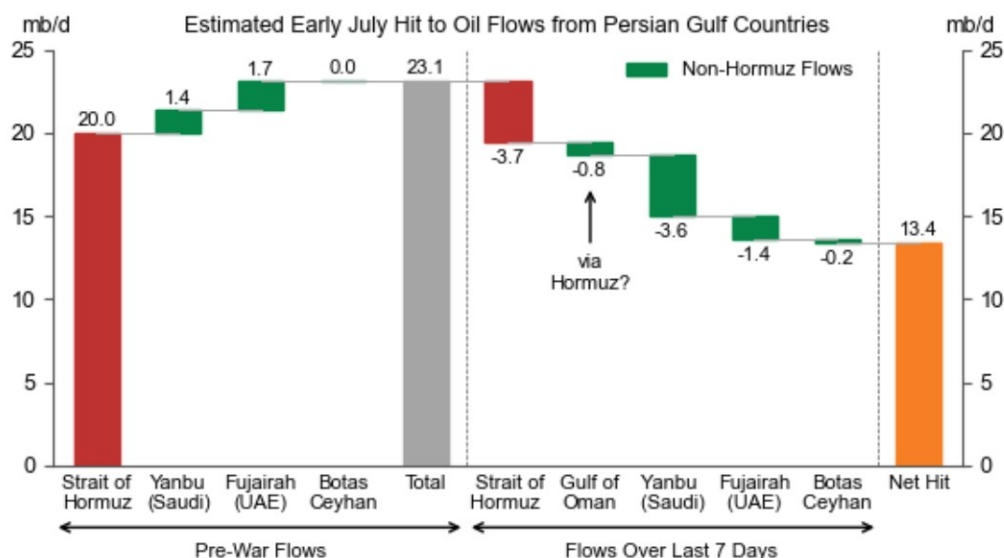
Initially Swift Persian Gulf Flows Recovery Is Reversing Following the Recent Escalation

Exhibit 1: Estimated Oil Flows From the Persian Gulf Recovered to Over 80% of Normal Levels in the First Two Weeks After the MoU but Retreated Back to Below 50% Over the Last Week Following Renewed Attacks on Tankers



Source: Kpler, S&P Global Commodities at Sea, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 2: Estimated Net Hit to Persian Gulf Flows Doubled Over the Last Week to 13.4mb/d, Implying that the Market Requires More Adjustment Mechanisms to Buffer the Hit

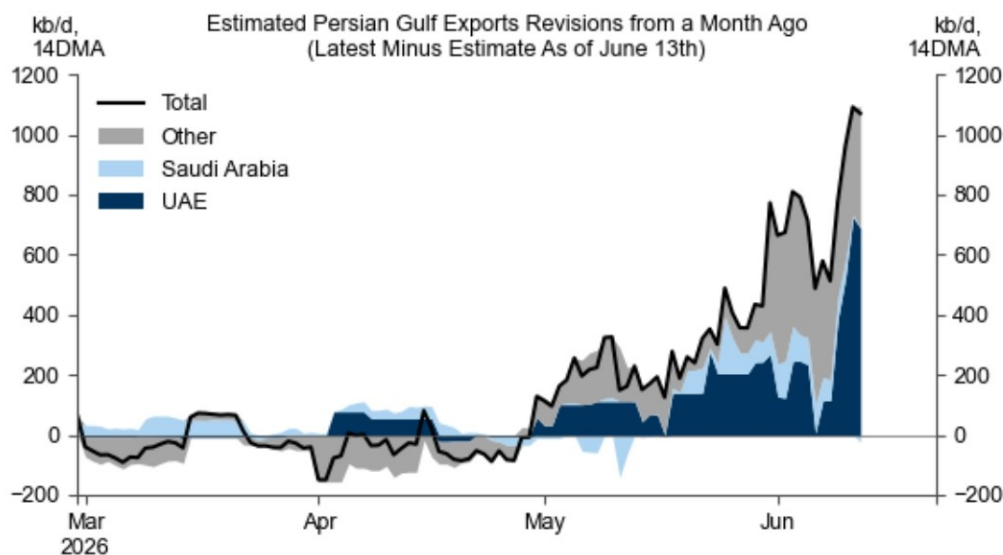


Source: Kpler, S&P Global Commodities at Sea, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Recently Estimated Observable Persian Gulf Flows May Be a Lower Bound on Total Gulf

Flows Given “Dark” Crossings

Exhibit 3: Estimates of Persian Gulf Flows as of Mid-June Have Been Revised Up by 1.1mb/d, With UAE Flows Driving 2/3 of the Revisions

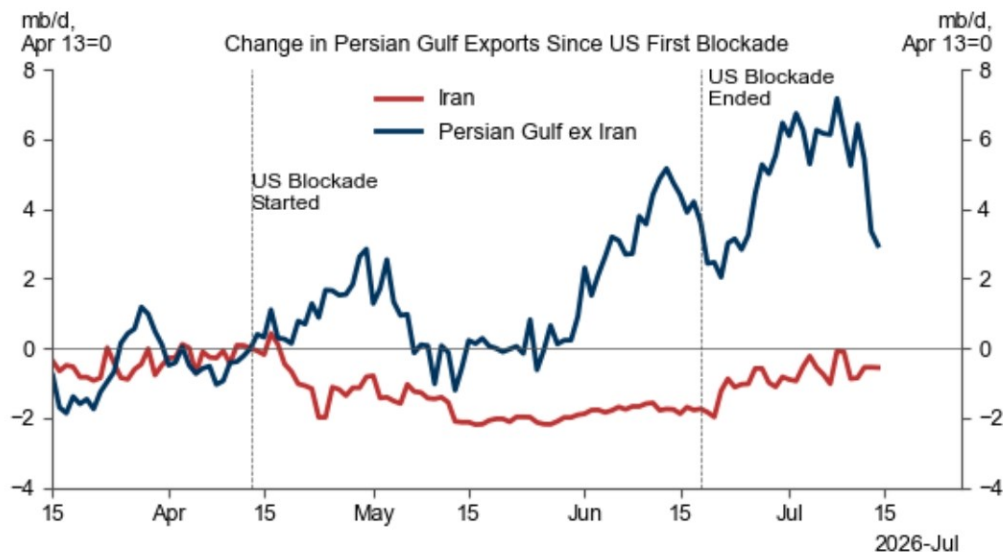


Source: Kpler, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Downside Risk to Further Flow Recovery

US Blockade Poses Downside Risks to Iranian Oil Flows

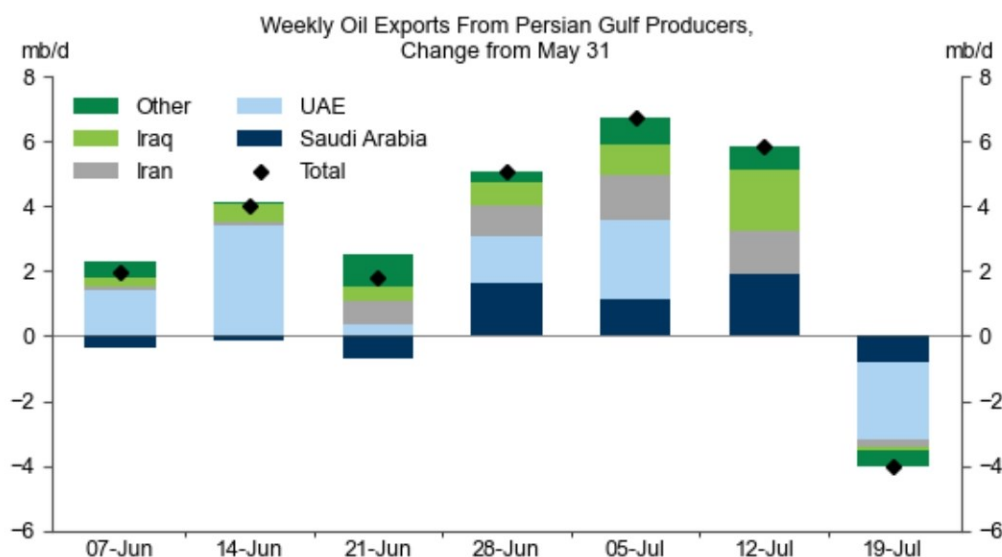
Exhibit 4: Iranian Oil Exports Decreased by 1.5-2mb/d During the First US Blockade While Other Persian Gulf Exports Increased by Nearly 4-5mb/d Over the Course of the Blockade



Source: Kpler, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

The Next Phase of Gulf Flow Recovery Could Be Slower Than the Initial Phase Even

After Geopolitical De-escalation

Exhibit 5: Saudi Arabia and UAE — Countries With the Largest Tanker Capacity and High-Quality Fields — Drove the Initial Recovery in the Persian Gulf Flows Since Early June

Source: Kpler, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

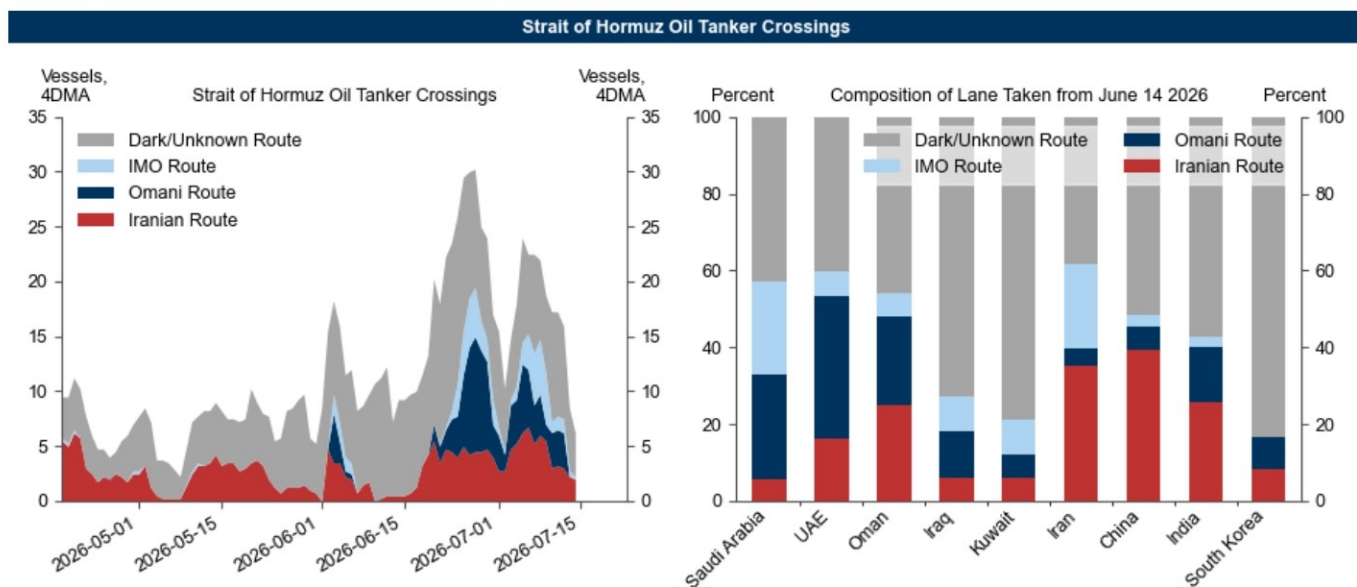
Exhibit 6: June Persian Gulf Production Losses Are Likely Smaller Than Our Month-Ago Expectations as UAE Production Beat Expectations, but 9–10mb/d of Crude Production Losses Are Yet to Recover

Average Persian Gulf Oil Production Losses in June vs February (mb/d)										
	Liquids	Crude		NGLs	Crude					
	Gulf Incl. Qatar	Gulf Incl. Qatar	Gulf Excl. Qatar	Gulf Incl. Qatar	Iran	Iraq	Kuwait	Qatar	Saudi Arabia	UAE
IEA (As of July 10)	11.2	9.1	8.1	2.2	1.4	2.6	1.2	0.9	3.4	-0.4
OPEC Secondary Sources (As of July 13)	-	-	7.0	-	0.8	2.2	1.1	-	3.3	-0.4
Kpler (As of June 19)	-	9.5	8.4	-	1.0	2.6	1.4	1.1	2.9	0.6
GS Balance (As of June 15)	12.8	10.5	9.4	2.3	0.8	2.7	1.8	1.1	3.0	1.0

Positive numbers represent losses; negative numbers represent gains.

Source: IEA, OPEC Secondary Sources, Kpler, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

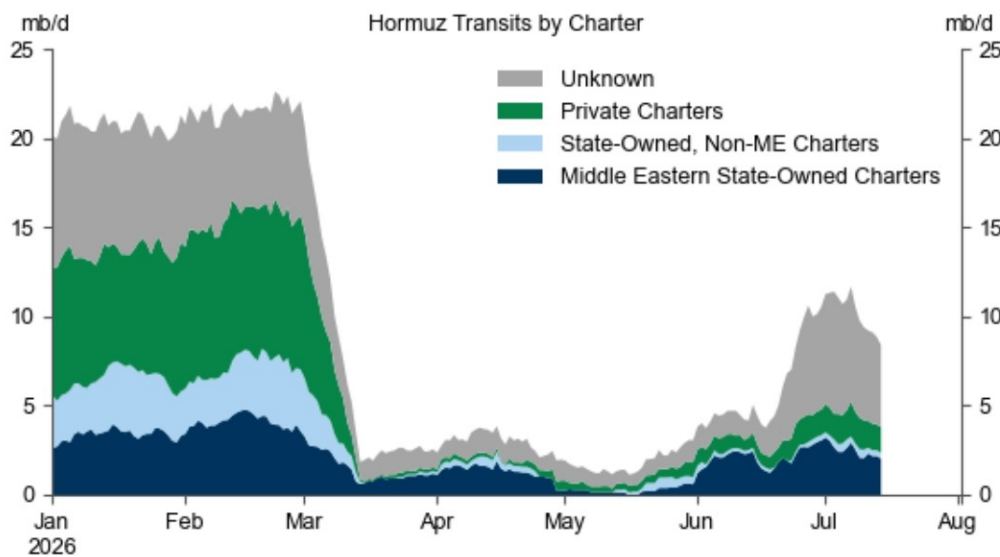
Exhibit 7: The Recent Decline in the Strait of Hormuz Crossings Is Driven by a Sharp Decline in Flows via Omani and IMO Central Routes Following Attacks of Tankers Using Those Routes



IMO stands for the International Maritime Organization.

Source: Kpler, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 8: While Middle Eastern State-Owned Charters Flows Recovered to 85% of Normal in Early July, Security Concerns Have Likely Been Weighing on Transits by Private and Non-Middle Eastern Shippers

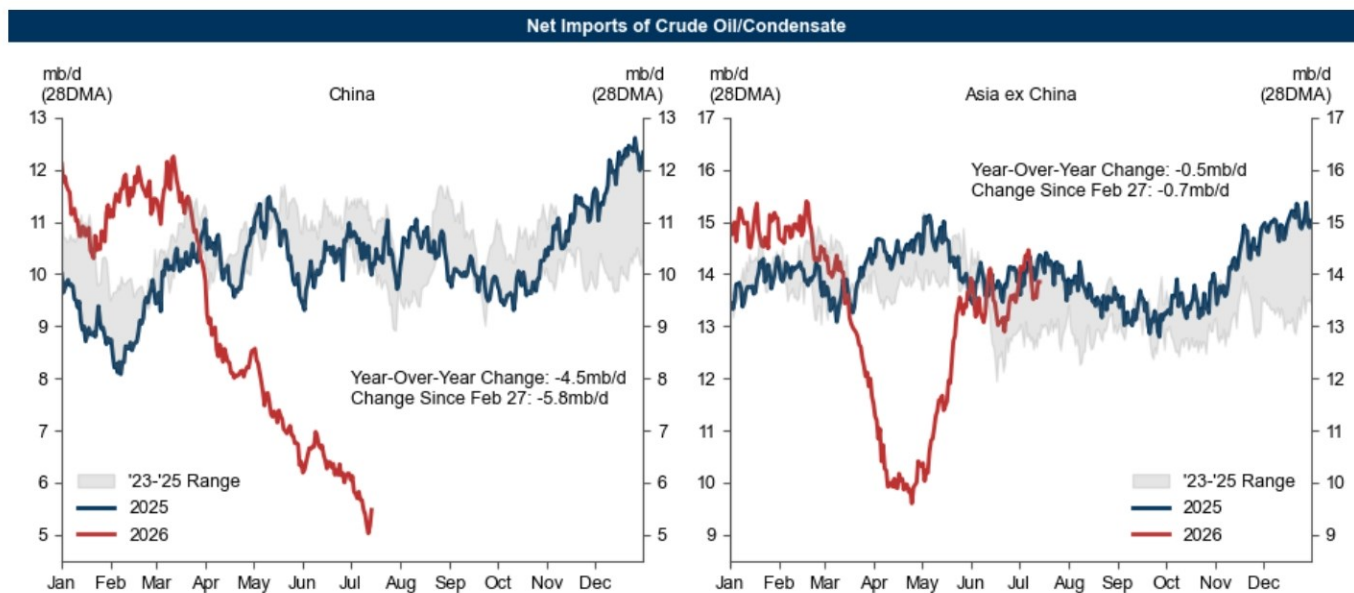


Source: Kpler, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

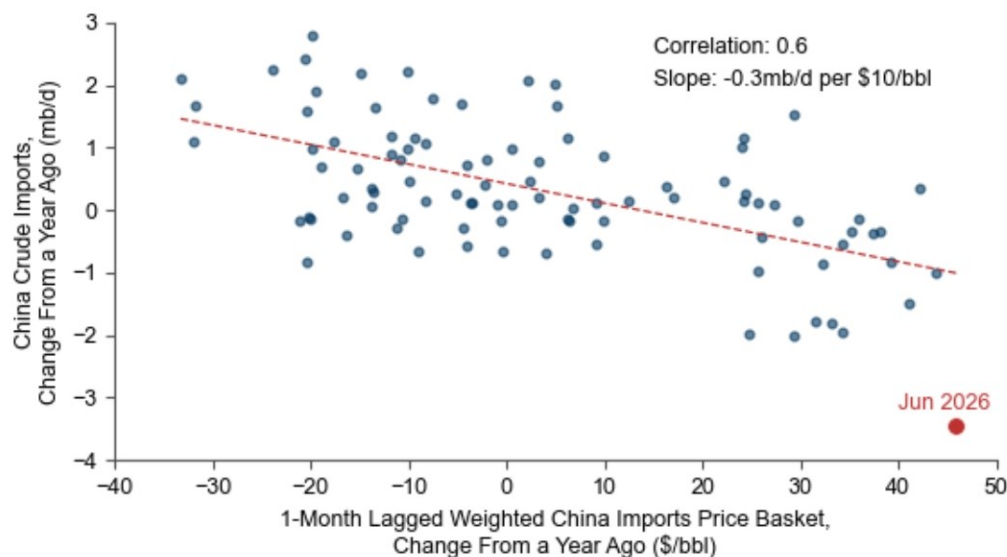
Low China Crude Imports Helped to Keep a Lid on Prices, for Now

Price-Sensitive Crude Imports Dropped as Large Stockpiles Helped to Meet Demand, But Will Likely Recover as Middle Eastern Producers Announced Price Declines for July

and August

Exhibit 9: China Crude Net Imports Declined to Nearly 5mb/d Year-Over-Year in Early July Despite a Steep Recovery in ex China Asia Imports

Source: Kpler, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 10: Large Crude Stockpiles Allow China Imports to Be Price Sensitive and Postpone Imports When Crude Prices Are High

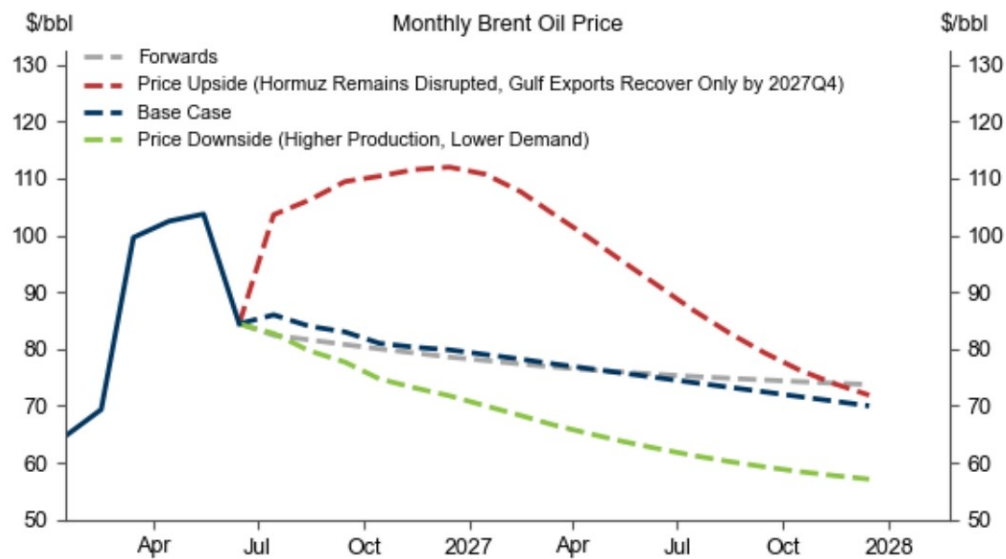
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Source: Platts, OPEC, Kpler, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Two-Sided Risks to Prices, but Skewed to the Upside in the Short-Run**Short-Run Upside Risks to Prices on Geopolitical Risks, but Medium-Run Downside**

Risks to Prices as Flows Have Proven to Be Able to Recover Fast After a Deescalation

Exhibit 11: Brent Could Overshoot \$110/bbl in 2026Q4 if the Gulf Export Recovery Continues to Stall, Delaying the Production Rebound and Requiring a Larger Demand Response



Source: ICE, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Disclosure Appendix

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